Less “Slop”, More Human:
Teaching writing style against LLMs

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Preview of upcoming talk

1. Pedagogical context and approach
2. Course readings and educational website
3. Cover letter style
4. Instructional style
5. Proposal style

The course I'll be discussing is ENGL 288, an intro TPC course that has 3 major projects over a 10-week quarter...

1. Professionalization (job market materials, incl. cover letter)

2. Instructional design (software or other instruction manual)

3. Change proposal (local community-based, team-based)

Whenever I incorporate AI into the classroom, I give students options to refuse it.

- Students can always refuse to use the technology, and they never have to justify this ethical decision
  - ➢ following Sano-Franchini, McIntyre, & Fernandes, *Refusing GenAI in Writing Studies: A Quickstart Guide*
- Students who practice refusal are given previously-generated examples to analyze and reflect on instead of generating new examples themselves
- Ultimately, I want students to develop both critical AI literacy and TPC genre knowledge: not fetishizing or condemning any single tool, but valuing their lived experience in relation to their communicative goals (and learning to critique AI style & tech)

To teach against "AI slop" style, we can assign TPC students readings on how LLMs actually write**.**

Use readings such as:

- Markey, B., Brown, D. W., Laudenbach, M., & Kohler, A. (2024). Dense and disconnected: Analyzing the sedimented style of ChatGPT-generated text at scale. *Written Communication*, 41(4), 571-600.

- Reinhart, A., Markey, B., Laudenbach, M., Pantusen, K., Yurko, R., Weinberg, G., & Brown, D. W. (2025). Do LLMs write like humans? Variation in grammatical and rhetorical styles. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 122(8), e2422455122.

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- Markey, B., Brown, D. W., Laudenbach, M., & Kohler, A. (2024). Dense and disconnected.
  - ➢ LLM-generated text is comparatively "dense and disconnected", "dialogically closed", "empty", and "fluffy"
    - ❖ manifests in "more *attributive adjectives*, *nouns*, and *prepositions*", "a **higher rate of grammatical transformation** from other parts of speech into nouns, such as through *nominalizations, participles, and gerunds*", "**fewer hedges** and **modals of possibility**"

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- Markey, B., Brown, D. W., Laudenbach, M., & Kohler, A. (2024). Dense and disconnected.
    - ➢ also finds that LLMs struggle at "**generating pedestrian examples**" to help clarify abstract concepts

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- Reinhart, A., Markey, B., Laudenbach, M., Pantusen, K., Yurko, R., Weinberg, G., & Brown, D. W. (2025). Do LLMs write like humans?

  - "large differences in grammatical, lexical, and stylistic features": using "*present participial clauses* at **2 to 5 times** the rate of human text" and "*nominalizations* at **1.5 to 2 times** the rate of humans", while using "the *agentless passive voice* at roughly **half** the rate as human texts"

    - significantly less *clausal co-ordination*: GPT-4o models avoid it, while all Llama 3 variants use it more than humans

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Feature Difference	LLM-coded example	Human-coded example
Attributive adjectives/nouns	"comprehensive regional transportation infrastructure plan"	"plan for transportation in the region"
Nominalizations	"evaluation of performance"	"evaluate how it performs"
Fewer hedges	"The model demonstrates improvement."	"The model may demonstrate improvement."
More participial clauses	"an event producing unexpectedly high readings…"	"[X happened] and it produced unexpectedly high readings"
Less agentless passive	"Researchers measured the samples."	"The samples were measured."
Less clausal coordination	"three-phase development framework"	"a framework was developed in three phases, and it explains…"

Exercise demo: AI slop style vs. a more human style

- **https://cpollak-uw.github.io/ai-style-exercises/**
  - Exercise set 1 includes side-by-side paragraphs roughly approximating each style, across three disciplines
  - Students are given sample sentences to match to the styles and other samples to revise and improve

Exercise demo: Spotting and revising AI slop across genres

- **https://cpollak-uw.github.io/ai-style-exercises/**
  - Exercise set 2 is broken up into cover letters, instructions, and proposals
  - Students are given sample sentences to identify, revise, and analyze in these different genres

Chatbot demo: Interactive exercises and textual revision tool

- **https://cpollak-uw.github.io/ai-style-exercises/**
  - Chatbot allows students to do the same exercises interactively
  - Also enables students to enter text and ask for revisions according to principles of “more human style”
    - Tested with GPT-generated cover letter, proposal, and instructions, and it did a pretty good job

I built an educational website for C's, which I've subsequently reorganized to follow the ENGL 288 course itself.

- The AI style readings come first: there's now a self-graded reading check quiz, plus discussion prompts on the two studies
- Then there is one activity page for each major project (cover letters, instructions, proposals)
  - ➢ on each page, students generate (or critique) a synthetic text, investigate its style, draft their own version, and edit it closely
  - ➢ students who refuse AI use are given previously-generated examples on every page
- Exercise sets 1–2 and the chatbot are still there for practice at any time
- Free to use and adapt: https://cpollak-uw.github.io/ai-style-exercises/

The first set of activities uncovers the weaknesses of synthetic cover letters and the strengths of human ones.

- Students upload their resumes to a university-licensed LLM chatbot and ask it to generate a cover letter in response to a real job ad

- They then investigate the peculiar language and argument style of the letter: *does it overuse and underuse the style features identified in the readings?*

- Students then begin their own letters “inside-out”: they identify the most interesting STAR stories (situation, task, action, results) they could tell, write those stories out first, and only then develop topic sentences, an introduction, and a conclusion

- This kind of inside-out approach is not achievable by LLMs

What do (read: *should*) students find? The concrete details have disappeared into abstraction.

- The (fictional) resume included real numbers: an Instagram account grown from 400 to 1,900 followers, and a donation drive that collected 800 lbs of food
- The generated letter: *"My experience managing social media operations..., driving significant audience growth and fostering meaningful community connections, underscores my capacity for impactful digital storytelling."*
  - ➢ the numbers are gone, and only the participial clauses and dense noun phrases remain
- A rewrite grounded in a STAR story: *"Last spring I ran our nonprofit's first donation drive, and by June we had collected 800 pounds of food and grown our Instagram from 400 to 1,900 followers."*

In the second set of activities, groups critique LLM-generated instructions for a tool they know well.

- Small groups use an LLM to generate instructions for installing and using a piece of software or an app that they all know quite well themselves
- They analyze the output by asking three kinds of questions:
  - **language style**: *is it dense and disconnected to the point of confusing the user?*
  - **supplementary discussion**: *does it explain steps the way you would for a friend or family member?*
  - **formatting**: *does it avoid bullets for ordered lists?*
- Finally, they rewrite the instructions themselves and analyze the differences in style and content

What do (read: *should*) groups find? The instructions bury the actions and leave out what a human user would say.

- Generated: *“The execution of the installer file enables the commencement of the installation process.”*
  - ➢ the user’s action is buried in nominalizations (who double-clicks what?)
  - ➢ there are no tips or warnings, and nothing tells you what you’ll see when a step works
  - ➢ the steps are bulleted rather than numbered, so users lose their place
- A group rewrite: *“3. Double-click the file you downloaded. Installing takes about a minute, and Zoom opens by itself when it’s done.”*

The third set of activities homes in on the language and argument style of LLM proposals.

- Students inspect the extent to which generated proposals overstate their cases through a lack of hedging and modality, or underexplain them through a lack of illustrative examples and narratives

- This analysis then transitions into composing practice that begins from argument (*what problem and solution do you want to define and advocate for?*) and narrative (*whose story are you trying to tell or uplift?*), targeted towards an actual human audience

- In editing activities, students refresh their understanding of the readings by closely checking their own writing for the various style features

What do students (read: *should*) students find? The proposal overstates its predictions and underexplains its problem.

- Generated: *“Extended hours will deliver transformative benefits… will drive measurable improvements in academic performance.”*
  - ➢ a rewrite with modality: *“if the library stays open later, students who work evening shifts could gain 10 or more study hours a week, and we would expect grades to benefit (though we’d want to measure this)”*
- Generated: *“students facing scheduling constraints stemming from employment obligations”*
  - ➢ a rewrite with narrative: a couple of sentences about one interviewed student who gets off work at 11 p.m. and finds the library dark
- Human writers tend to do the reverse: they hedge their predictions, and they describe the present in concrete detail

What comes next

- I’ll start using these activities in my course in Autumn 2026, and report back in a journal or online publication
- I still wonder if I’m scoping “AI slop” vs. “more human style” too narrowly, and/or if more features could be added to either bucket (e.g. punctuation, examples, narrative details, source engagement)
- The website is free to use and adapt: https://cpollak-uw.github.io/ai-style-exercises/
- I’d love your feedback on the work so far!

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Questions?

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Email me!